Outlook

## Requirements Confirmation – Author's Workbench

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**Date** Tue 9/1/2026 5:00 PM
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Hi Imbi,

Thank you again for meeting with us and for providing such helpful feedback on our prototype.

Following our discussion, we have summarised our current understanding of the key requirements below. We would like to confirm that we have interpreted your requirements correctly before we proceed further with development.

**1. Core purpose and workflow**

Our understanding is that Author's Workbench is primarily a **plotting and story planning tool**, rather than a novel writing tool. Its main purpose is to support story structure planning, chapter plotting and plot beat mapping. The actual manuscript writing will take place in **Scrivener**.

The expected workflow is:

1. Authors complete their initial story plotting and structural planning in Author's Workbench.
2. Once the plan is finalised, they can export their plan for use in their writing workflow, with **Excel being the highest-priority export format**.
3. Scrivener will then serve as the main tool for the actual manuscript writing.
4. Minor plot changes during writing do not necessarily need to be reflected back in Author's Workbench, while major structural or plot changes may require the story to be replanned in the tool.

**2. Key functional requirements**

Based on our discussion, we understand the following to be important requirements:

- **Chapter plot summaries:** Each chapter should display a short summary of its core plot, rather than primarily displaying the chapter word count.
- **Character–chapter association:** Users should be able to quickly add/associate characters from the chapter view. Character participation in chapters should then be reflected in the corresponding character profile, providing a two-way relationship between characters and chapters.
- **Custom story structures:** As a future enhancement, users should be able to create and save their own story structures by defining the percentage positions of story beats.

**3. Export and integration**

We also understand that **Excel export is the highest-priority external integration/export feature**.

The tool should support export of the core plotting information, including:

- Chapter plans
- Chapter plot summaries
- Story beats and their distribution
- Other relevant plotting information where appropriate

Our understanding is that Excel is prioritised because of its flexibility and broad compatibility with writers' existing workflows.

**4. Saving and Backing Up Projects**

We would also like to confirm how you would prefer projects to be saved.

Our current approach is to have the application **automatically save the author's work while they are using it**, so they would not need to manually save their project after every change.

As the application is designed to run in the browser, we would also provide an **Export Project** option. This would allow authors to save a copy of their entire project as a file (JSON file) on their computer as a backup. If needed, they could later use an **Import Project** option to restore their project and continue working on it.

This would also provide a simple way for authors to keep a backup of their work or move a project to another computer.

Could you please let us know if the above accurately reflects your requirements and priorities, and whether the proposed local storage and JSON backup approach would be acceptable for your intended use of the tool? Please also let us know if there is anything we have misunderstood or missed.

Thank you again for your time and guidance!

Best wishes,
Angelina
**Workbench Elves**